Reported Speech

The big idea

Direct speech gives a speaker's exact words in quotation marks. **Reported (indirect) speech** reports the meaning in our own words, without quotes. When the **reporting verb** is in the past tense, we usually shift **tenses, pronouns, and time and place words**.

DIRECT VS REPORTED

Direct: Lencho said, "I need a hundred pesos."
Reported: Lencho said that **he needed** a hundred pesos.

Rule 1: Tense changes (when the reporting verb is past)

Direct	Reported
simple present (*do*)	simple past (*did*)
present continuous (*is doing*)	past continuous (*was doing*)
present perfect (*has done*)	past perfect (*had done*)
simple past (*did*)	past perfect (*had done*)
will	would
can	could
may	might
shall	should

Direct	Reported
must	had to (or must)

No change when: the reporting verb is in the present/future (*He says, "I am tired" → He says that he is tired*), or the reported words state a **universal truth / habitual fact** (*The teacher said, "The earth revolves round the sun" → The teacher said that the earth revolves round the sun*).

Rule 2: Pronouns

Change pronouns according to who is speaking and who is listening. *She said to me, "**I** like **your** dress." → She told me that **she** liked **my** dress.*

Rule 3: Time and place words

Direct	Reported
now	then
today	that day
tomorrow	the next day / the following day
yesterday	the previous day / the day before
this / these	that / those
here	there
ago	before
next week	the following week

Rule 4: Statements

Reporting verb: **said / told** (+ object), connector **that**.

- *He said, "I am going to Goa." → He **said that** he **was** going to Goa.*
- *She said to me, "I will call you tomorrow." → She **told me that** she **would** call me **the next day**.*

Rule 5: Questions

- Reporting verb: **asked / enquired / wanted to know**.
- The question becomes a **statement order** (subject before verb); remove the question mark.
- **Yes/No questions** → use **if / whether**. *He said to me, "Are you ready?" → He asked me **if I was** ready.*
- **Wh- questions** → keep the **wh-word**. *She said, "Where do you live?" → She asked **where I lived**.*

DON'T KEEP QUESTION ORDER

× *He asked where was I going.* ✓ *He asked where **I was** going.*

Rule 6: Commands and requests (imperatives)

- Reporting verb: **ordered, commanded, told, requested, advised, begged, warned**.
- Use **to + base verb**; for negative, **not to + base verb**.
- *The teacher said, "Sit down." → The teacher **ordered** us **to sit** down.*
- *She said, "Please help me." → She **requested** me **to help** her.*
- *Mother said, "Don't touch the stove." → Mother **warned** me **not to touch** the stove.*

Rule 7: Exclamations and wishes

- Reporting verb: **exclaimed with joy/sorrow/surprise, wished, prayed**.
- *He said, "What a beautiful sight!" → He **exclaimed with wonder** that it was a very beautiful sight.*
- *They said, "Good morning, sir." → They **wished** him good morning.*

BOARD-STYLE DIALOGUE TO REPORT

Valli: "How much is the fare to town?" Conductor: "Thirty paise."
→ Valli **asked** the conductor **how much the fare to town was**. The conductor **replied that it was** thirty paise.

EXAM STRATEGY

In CBSE "reported speech in context" questions, read the dialogue, identify the **type** of sentence (statement/question/command), choose a suitable **reporting verb**, then change tense, pronoun and time words in that order. Write the complete sentence.

Quick recap

- Past reporting verb → shift tense back one step; will → would, can → could.
- Change pronouns, time and place words (now → then, tomorrow → the next day).
- Statements: said/told that. Questions: asked + if/whether or wh-word, statement order. Commands: ordered/requested + (not) to + verb.
- No tense change for universal truths or present reporting verbs.

Practice questions

1. He said, "I am busy." Choose the correct reported form.

   (a) He said that I am busy. (b) He said that he was busy. (c) He said that he is busy now. (d) He told that he was busy.

2. She said to me, "Are you coming tomorrow?"

   (a) She asked me that I was coming tomorrow. (b) She asked me are you coming the next day. (c) She said me if I was coming tomorrow. (d) She asked me if I was coming the next day.

3. The teacher said, "The earth is round." Reported speech:

   (a) The teacher said that the earth is round. (b) The teacher said that the earth was round. (c) The teacher told the earth is round. (d) The teacher said that the earth had been round.

4. Mother said to me, "Don't play in the rain."

   (a) Mother told me don't play in the rain. (b) Mother asked me that I should not play in the rain. (c) Mother warned me not to play in the rain. (d) Mother said me not playing in the rain.

5. "Where do you live?" he asked her. Choose the reported form.

   (a) He asked her where did she live. (b) He asked her where she lived. (c) He asked her where do you live. (d) He asked her that where she lived.

6. In reported speech, "will" usually changes to

   (a) shall (b) can (c) would (d) might

7. "now" in direct speech changes to

   (a) today (b) before (c) there (d) then

8. Report the dialogue: Anil: "Can you cook?" Hari: "I can cook very well." Anil: "Make some tea for me."

Answers: 1. b 2. d 3. a 4. c 5. b 6. c 7. d 8. see notes